

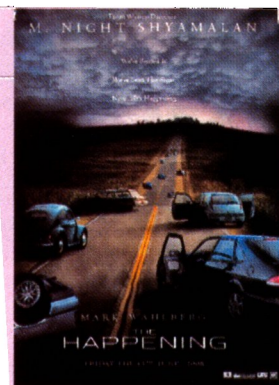
OVERSEAS MARKET

Taking on the World

If US studios can make Indian movies, Indian studios can also cross over

It took Ronnie Screwvala a tour of Manoj Night Shyamalan's ranch in Philadelphia last year to convince him to do *The Happening* as a \$30 million co-production between Fox Searchlight and UTV. It took Reliance officials several trips before settling on buying 435 screens in the US. Hollywood, or at least international productions, now seem just a phone call away. Disney is making its animated debut with YashRaj Films' *Roadside Romeo*, Warner Bros will debut with *Chandni Chowk to China*, while Sony BMG has signed a Rs 100-crore four film deal with Mukesh-Mahesh Bhatt's Vishesh Films. Foreign movies are picking up Indian actors for roles big and

small, from Anil Kapoor who stars in Danny Boyle's *Slumdog Millionaire* to Aishwarya Rai Bachchan who will be in *Pink Panther 2*. Diaspora films such as Manish Acharya's *Loins of Punjab Presents* has already shown there is an audience in India which Rohan Sippy hopes to replicate with Anuvab Pal's *The President is Coming* starring Konkona Sen Sharma and Shernaz Patel, whereas UTV's co-production of Mira Nair's *The Namesake* has shown that it is possible to make Indian movies appeal to Americans. Whether it is Reliance's three-film deal with Ashok Amritraj or UTV's two-film arrangement with Will Smith, Bollywood is going beyond New Jersey's Regal Theatre.

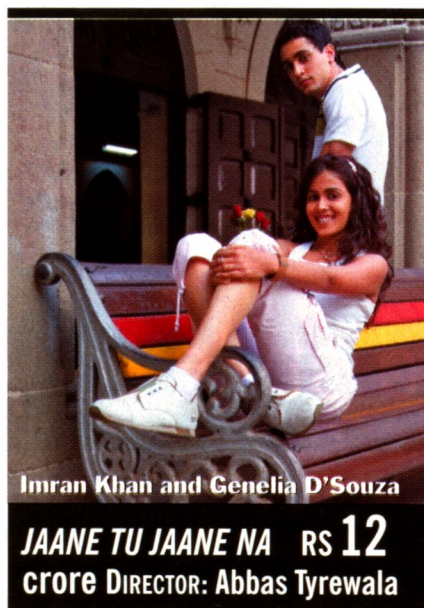


MOVING IMAGES: A still from Shyamalan's *The Happening*

"You can choose the film you want to make and its audience."

ROHAN SIPPY
DIRECTOR-PRODUCER

But is it Bollywood shining or Bollywood shamming? Several independent producers, who relied on the old system of advances from individual exhibitors are now idling their time. Studio floors in Mumbai are booked—as a result, a city like Bangkok currently has five Hindi films being shot almost simultaneously. Everyone is signed on in "non-exclusive contracts". So while Anurag Basu directs Hrithik Roshan in *Kites*, to be co-produced with Eros and Carving Dreams, UTV has already announced a three-film deal with him. While Imtiaz Ali gets ready to direct a film for Saif Ali Khan's Illuminati Films, Sajid Nadiadwala and Shree Ashtavinayak have also declared he is directing their next films. There is a certain amount of desperation in the



air, with companies signing on whoever they can find. Almost anyone will do. UTV has announced a two-film deal with Shahid Kapur, a two-film deal with John Abraham and even Kangana Ranuat (who is barely four films old).

And to think that just two years ago, when Adlabs offered Akshay a Rs 14.5 crore deal for four films and Hrithik Rs 35 crore for three films, it seemed as if the Rubicon had been crossed. As strategic consultant Prabhat Choudhary puts it, "Bollywood launches a new consumer product every Friday with one-tenth of FMCG budgets." And every Friday, the product gets bigger.

The advent of the film school generation (from FFI products, directors such as Rajat Kapoor and Sriram Raghavan, to foreign trained Shimit Amin and Manish Acharya) and advertising gurus (R. Balki and writer Jaideep Sahni) has lent a new substance to the old fashioned style of storytelling. It has coaxed Saeed Akhtar Mirza out of retirement in Goa to make *Ek Toh Chance* for PNC and caused Sudhir Mishra, who couldn't make a film for seven years, between 1996 and 2003, to coast from one studio floor to another. It's the nature of the money. It demands—and gets—more movies. And a more adventurous spirit. ■

BOLLYWOOD: A GROWTH STORY

MOVIE-GOERS	BOX-OFFICE REVENUES	MULTIPLEXES
2001—2.8 billion	2001—\$593 mn	10
2002—3.2 bn	2002—\$658 mn	19
2003—3.42 bn	2003—\$643 mn	34
2004—3.59 bn	2004—\$707 mn	54
2005—3.77 bn	2005—\$1.19 bn	68
2006—3.95 bn	2006—\$1.41 bn	101*

(*) THE FIGURE IS NOW 165. THE AVERAGE NUMBER OF SCREENS IS FOUR.

SOURCE: AT KEARNEY AND SHRINGAR FILMS